

time, courtesy EA. In the Good campaign, you will be in control of the races of Men, Elves and Dwarves, purging evil from Middle Earth, with the aid of Heroes like Gandalf, Glorfindel, Arwen and many other familiar faces.

There's also the Evil campaign, which lets you squish all those *nasty hobbitses* and elves into the ground and spread Darkness in the land—more enjoyable than you'd think.

Draw Your Swords

BFME2 won't win any awards for revolutionising the concept of the RTS—the job description is still the same: gather resources, build units, guard base, poke enemies in the eye; repeat as desired.

What we should give EA a pat on the back for is breaking away from the standard control-panel-at-the-bottom interface that's become so tired, and making an interface that's incredibly intuitive and convenient.

Another welcome addition is the Planning Mode, which lets you pre-issue commands to all your units and then make them all execute at the same time.

BFME2 is a game that encourages you to get out there

and fight your enemy tooth and nail—as your units gain battle experience, they will gain more skills that you can have them use in battle. The magical powers of heroes, too, only come with more fighting experience. You will be rewarded for being aggressive with Power Points, which you can then trade in for powers, like the ability to shroud your troops in mist or cause devastating earthquakes.

All Hail The Dark Lord

In the skirmishes, you can hunt down Gollum on the map (not an easy task, mind you—he's slippery) and kill him to make him drop the One Ring. This is a highly recommended activity, for your opponent will also be alerted of the dropping of the Ring—and all hell will break loose as you try to bring it back to your base safe and sound. If you thought that an RTS could never give you a rush of adrenaline, this should make you feel pretty silly.

If you manage to bring the Ring back to your camp, you can summon either Galadriel if you're on the good side or the Dark Lord Sauron himself if you've sided with evil—both (obviously) immensely powerful.

Summoning Sauron will probably guarantee you a clear win unless you manage to botch up your game *really* badly. Being the Dark Lord and everything, he will inspire fear in the opposing camp, causing inexperienced units to run like chickens. As he saunters across the map, he will decimate armies in a sneeze, bring down walls more easily than we crush Styrofoam, and will leave your opponent (human or AI) crying like a baby. One unit was never this much fun.

Slaves Of The Ring

Fans of *The Lord of the Rings* are going to love this game. Every aspect of the gameplay makes perfect sense in the context of the book. Take away all the LOTR magic, and *BFME2* still holds its own as a solid strategy game with a great interface and devilishly nasty AI.

One fair bit of advice: when you go out and buy it (which you must), try and find the DVD—the copy we got for review was (God help us) a 6-pack—for beer that's fine, for CDs, atrocious.■

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